

COMRADES AGAIN Nitish Kumar and RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav after meeting Sonia Gandhi in New Delhi on September 25

all in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls," he said.

Inside his sprawling bungalow, Nitish sat in his sparely furnished drawing room with close aides—Bihar minister Sanjay Jha and Janata Dal (United) national president Rajiv Ranjan alias Lalan Singh. The Bihar CM, while ensuring that every visitor was served tea, looked unflustered by the enormity of the task he has undertaken. Dooubtless, stitching a unified front among opposition parties is a work in progress requiring infinite patience. It might take weeks, if not months, to fructify, says a confidant. In private conversations, an optimistic Nitish tells visitors that a total unification of the opposition, as he has been calling for, may take him across the country. The endeavour, he says, is less difficult than expected. Opposition leaders, according to the feedback Nitish has received, have been watching the BJP juggernaut gaining in strength and audacity—it holds power in 17 states and Union territories—with increasing apprehension, and are expected to come together to face the challenge.

IMPORTANCE OF THE CONGRESS

When Nitish and Lalu met Sonia Gandhi in the evening of September 25, they asked her, as president of the biggest opposition party, to also take the initiative for a unified front. Sonia is believed to have promised to hold a discussion after the Congress presidential election. That very Sunday, not far from Delhi, over 90 Rajasthan Congress MLAs loyal to CM Ashok Gehlot threatened to resign, throwing the party into a crisis. The Bihar CM has taken note of the developments, but he is not "unnecessarily worried" at the fragility displayed within the Congress, points out the confidant.

"The CM has a plan in place and a lot of it hinges on regional leaders too. Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, K. Chandrashekar Rao in Telangana, M.K. Stalin in Tamil Nadu, Uddhav Thackeray and Sharad Pawar in Maharashtra, Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi, Akhilesh Yadav in UP and Tejashwi Yadav in Bihar. The BJP has formidable adversaries in different regions, and we all need to ensure that these forces work in